

HLD Chapter 0: Intuitive Distributed Systems Primer & Visual Metaphors

Core Learning Objective: Eliminate the abstract intimidation of High-Level Design. Master every core distributed systems building block using vivid real-world analogies, understand the 10 systems side-by-side in a single matrix, and practice with the 45-minute blank interview template.

1. The Distributed Systems Metaphor Dictionary (Zero Jargon)

Whenever a distributed systems concept feels confusing, ground your thinking in these intuitive physical analogies:



2. The 13 High-Level Systems Rosetta Stone Comparison

Click on any system to jump directly into its end-to-end architecture, back-of-the-envelope math, database schema, and failure mode deep dives:

System	Traffic Type	Read : Write Ratio	Primary Storage	Primary Cache	The Single Hardest Bottleneck
1. Messaging App (WhatsApp)	Bi-directional Real-Time	1 : 1	Cassandra (LSM-Tree)	Redis (Session registry)	50M open WebSockets + offline delivery
2. Ticketing Platform	Flash Spikes (Concerts)	5 : 1	PostgreSQL (ACID)	Redis (Distributed lock + TTL)	Zero double-booking across 50,000 users in 5s
3. Photo Feed (Instagram)	Read-Heavy (Photos)	50 : 1	Cassandra + S3	CDN (Edge) + Redis (Timelines)	Celebrity fan-out on write explosion
4. Distributed Scheduler	Compute / Batch Heavy	1 : 1	PostgreSQL + etcd	Timing Wheel in RAM	Worker crash failure recovery + leader election
5. Video Streaming (YouTube)	High Bandwidth Egress	100 : 1	S3 (Object Store)	Multi-Tier CDN Edge	Adaptive Bitrate chunking without playback stall
6. E-Commerce (Amazon)	Financial Transactions	10 : 1	MySQL (Partitioned)	Redis (Atomic Lua inventory)	Multi-service inventory/payment Saga rollback
7. Proximity Service (Yelp)	Geospatial Read-Heavy	100 : 1	PostGIS + ScyllaDB	Redis (H3 Spatial Indices)	Fast nearest-neighbor search without 2D lag
8. Mutual Match (Tinder)	High Write / Swipes	1 : 1	DynamoDB / Cassandra	Redis (Sets of user likes)	Sub-10ms mutual match detection on swipes
9. Ride Dispatch (Uber)	Massive GPS Ingestion	1 : 5 (Write Heavy!)	CockroachDB (Trips)	Redis (H3 Spatial driver grid)	1.25M GPS writes/sec without DB meltdown
10. Social Feed (Twitter/X)	Read-Heavy Microblogging	10 : 1	Cassandra + S3	Redis Cluster (800 IDs timeline)	Celebrity fan-out hybrid push-pull architecture
11. Distributed Cache (Redis)	Ultra Low-Latency In-Memory	10 : 1	Memory (RAM + RDB/AOF)	Redis Master-	Split-brain prevention &

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				Replica Shards	consistent hash slot rebalancing
12. Search Engine (Elasticsearch)	High-Volume Inverted Index	5 : 1	Lucene Segments (Disk)	File System Page Cache	Near real-time index refresh & segment merge throttling
13. Time-Series (Prometheus)	Append-Only Metrics Flush	1 : 100 (Write Heavy!)	Gorilla TSDB Chunking	Head Chunk Memory Buffer	10M metric samples/sec ingestion & compactor downsampling

3. The 45-Minute Printable Interview Cheat Template

Print this 1-page canvas to structure your whiteboard during mock interviews:



Further Reading

- [System Design Primer](#)
- [AWS Builders' Library](#)
- [Wikipedia: Eventual consistency](#)

Check Yourself

Answer in your head or on paper first, then open each answer.

- ▶ 1. What does 'eventual consistency' mean?
- ▶ 2. What is a single point of failure?
- ▶ 3. What is idempotency?
- ▶ 4. What is backpressure?